Google Maps doesn't know what Indian roads feel like

A PM lens on route choice, rerouting consent and why efficiency is the wrong default for 1.4 billion people.

OVERVIEW

Framework Followed

01 **Identify the user**
Who is actually in the car?

02 **Map the user journey**
What does the current experience look like?

03 **Find the friction**
Where does it break, and why?

04 **Diagnose root causes**
Emotions, patterns, and the real problem

05 **Propose solutions**
Feasible changes which creates minimal friction

06 **Define success metrics**
What does winning look like?

STEP 01 · IDENTIFY THE USER

Who is actually in the car?



The family driver

Elderly parents + young kids on board and a larger car

CORE NEED

Comfort > Speed · Highway preferred · Avoid narrow lanes



The older / anxious driver

Less comfortable with tight gullies or mid-trip rerouting.

CORE NEED

Predictable roads · Low cognitive load · No surprise turns



The large vehicle driver

Truck, tempo or big car. Road width is a hard constraint.

CORE NEED

Road-width aware · Avoid low bridges · No pocket streets



The efficiency maximiser

Solo commuter, city expert.

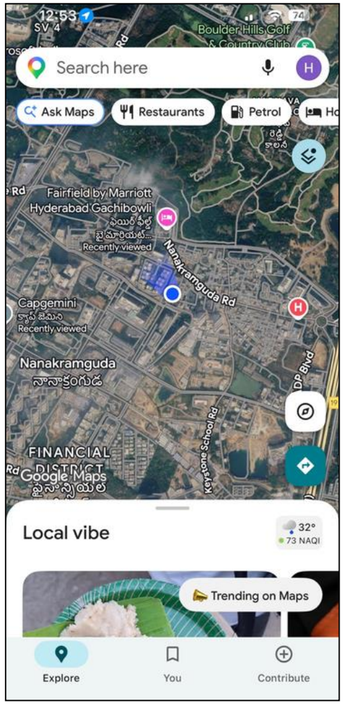
CORE NEED

Fastest route · Real-time rerouting

Key insight: The current algorithm is built for this persona.

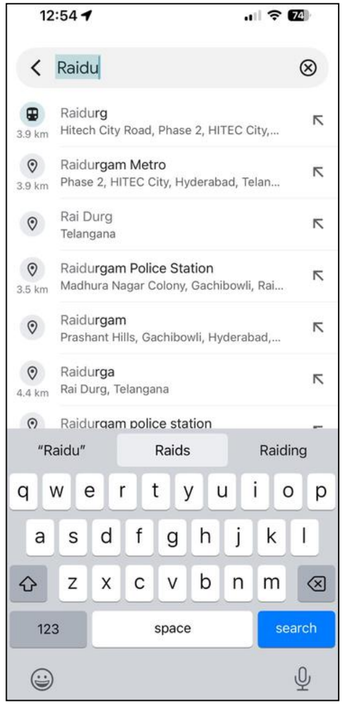
STEP 02 · USER JOURNEY

What does the current experience look like?



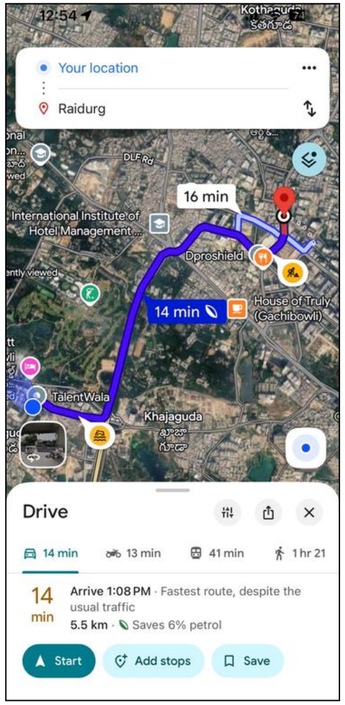
1

Open the app



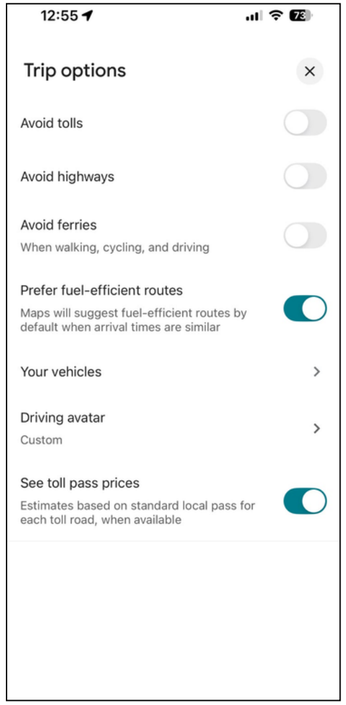
2

Enter destination



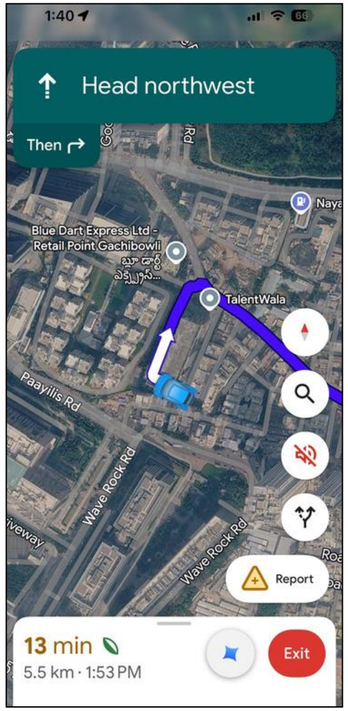
3

see the ETA, choose mode of travel



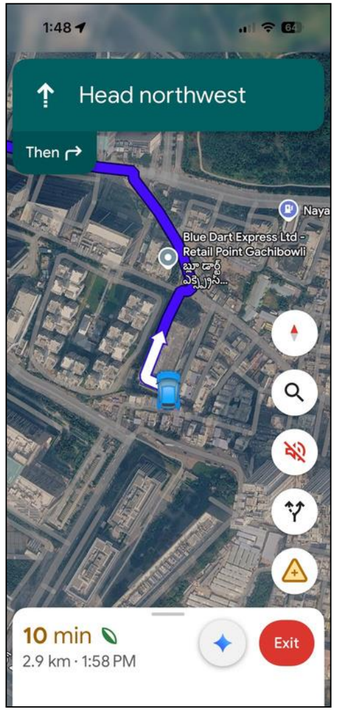
4

more options can be chosen



5

start journey



6

Discovers bad road mid-trip

STEP 03 · FIND THE FRICTION

Pain Points

Friction 1 · Lack of route description

Route cards show ETA and distance and nothing else. No road type, no lane count and no neighbourhood quality.

Indian cities alternate between 6-lane highways and 4-foot gullies within 500 metres. An algorithm optimised for time will confidently route a large car through a lane built for a rickshaw.

Friction 2 · The silent reroute

When a user deviates, Maps reroutes instantly and silently , no notification in the first 10–15 seconds, no offer to return to the original path or get a reroute.

In cities with poor U-turn infrastructure and one-way systems, most Indian cities — an automatic reroute can mean 20 minutes of new confusion for an older driver who took a wrong turn.

"The reroute happens before the user has had time to realise they've made a mistake and decide how they want to fix it."

STEP 04 · DIAGNOSE ROOT CAUSES

Emotions real problem

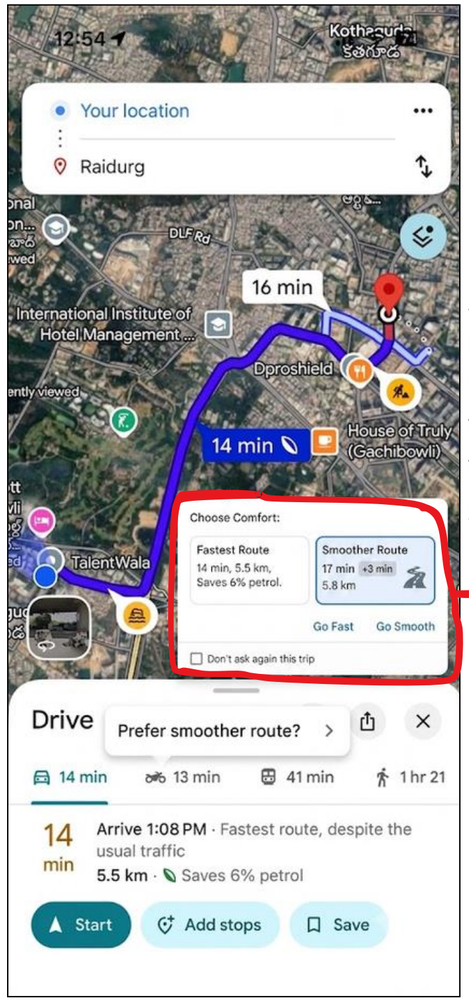
😰 **Loss of control**	The app decides before the user has processed what happened
😤 **Betrayal of expectation**	Chose what looked like a safe route. Got narrow lanes, speed bumps, bad roads.
😵 **Cognitive overload**	Processing a new route while driving unfamiliar roads, often with passengers
😶 **No vocabulary to express preference**	No way to tell the app 'I want comfort, not speed' for this trip

These are not edge cases — they are repeated patterns across cities, vehicle types, age groups, and experience levels.

STEP 05 · PROPOSE SOLUTIONS

Improvement Ideas

01 Per-journey route preferences



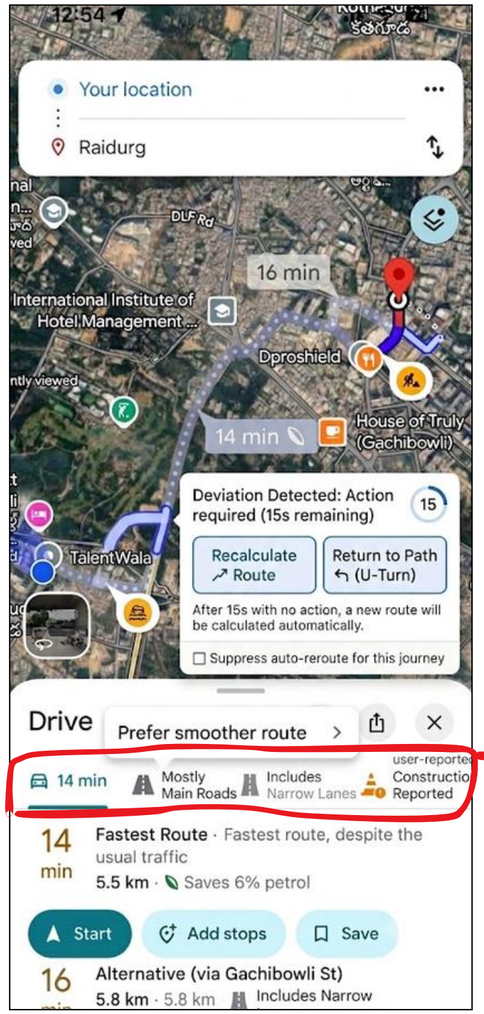
An expandable chip on the route screen , comfort vs speed, vehicle size, road type , that expires after the trip. Does not change global settings

02 Rerouting consent prompt



On deviation, suppress auto-reroute for 15s. Show: 'Reroute' or 'Return to route'. After 15s with no action, reroute as normal.

03 Road quality signals on route cards



One icon row per route: 'mostly main roads', 'includes narrow lanes', 'construction reported'.

STEP 06 · SUCCESS METRICS

Metrics To Track

METRIC	WHAT IT MEANS	
Route completion rate	% of journeys finished on originally chosen route without abandonment	
Reroute consent interaction rate	% of users who actively choose 'Reroute' or 'Return' vs letting it time out	
'Return to route' selection rate	Reveals how many users were silently frustrated before	
Route preference panel adoption	% of sessions that open the panel, segmented by Road quality	
Post-trip negative feedback	Thumbs-down rate for 'uncomfortable route' , track before and after launch	
Session length inflation	15s rerouting window should not materially increase trip time for genuine wrong turns	Guardrail

The best navigation product is not the one that always knows the fastest route.

It is the one that knows what 'best' means for this driver,

on this trip, with this car full of people counting on them.

Images in this deck are AI-generated or screenshot. All ideas, opinions, and recommendations are my own.